



A WORKER arranges goods at a store in Havana, where power and water outages mean many can't cook. NATALIA FAVRE For The Times

SOCAL SHERIFF SEIZES 650,000 BALLOTS

Riverside County's Bianco, a top GOP governor candidate, draws harsh rebuke.

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco, a leading Republican candidate for governor, has seized more than 650,000 ballots from last November's election to determine, he says, whether they were fraudulently counted.

"This investigation is simple: Physically count the ballots and compare that result with the total votes recorded," Bianco said at a news conference Friday.

The unusual probe drew a sharp rebuke from California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta, who said in a statement that it is "unprecedented in both scope and scale" and appears "not to be based on facts or evidence."

Critics, meanwhile, said Bianco's ballot seizure is a threat to democracy and another attempt by Republican election deniers to disenfranchise voters.

"There is no indication, anywhere in the United States, of widespread voter fraud," Bonta said. "Counts, recounts, hand counts, audits, and court cases all support this."

According to Bonta's office, Bianco's department on Feb. 26 seized about 1,000 boxes of ballot materials in Riverside County related to the November election for Proposition 50, which temporarily redrew the state's congressional districts to favor Democrats in response to partisan redistricting in Republican states, including Texas.

In a March 4 letter to Bianco, Bonta said the seizure of the ballots "sets a dangerous precedent and will only sow distrust in our elections." He threatened to seek legal recourse if Bianco does not halt his investigation.

Bonta also said he has "serious concerns" about whether Bianco had probable cause to obtain two warrants for the election materials and questioned whether Bianco had concealed important information from the magistrate judge who approved the [See Ballots, A7]

Anxiety over voting limits

High court case and GOP bill stir worry in Alaska, where mail balloting is a necessity. **NATION, A6**

U.S. oil blockade takes toll on people of Cuba

Blackouts push struggling island to crisis point

By Kate Linthicum | REPORTING FROM HAVANA

Reggaeton boomed in a neighborhood bar in Old Havana on a recent night, when, suddenly, the music stopped and everything went dark.

The customers groaned. Another blackout.

A U.S. blockade on oil shipments to Cuba has plunged the island into its worst energy crisis in modern history. The country's already cratering economy now teeters on the verge of collapse, with vehicles idled by a lack of gas, hospitals forced to cancel surgeries and millions living without a steady supply of electricity and water.

It is the result of a calculated pressure campaign by President Trump, whose administration is negotiating with Cuba's leaders over the future of the communist-ruled Caribbean island.

People fed up with rolling blackouts have staged sporadic protests in recent days, banging pots and shouting slogans against the government, rare demonstrations in a country known for repressing dissent.

Some power outages hit isolated areas, but in recent weeks Cuba has experienced three islandwide blackouts. The most recent one struck Sat- [See Cuba, A3]

New outage: Cuba restoring power after 3rd total blackout this month. **WORLD, A3**

Local TV journalists lose jobs in an industry in crisis

Ratings fall as more viewers turn to streaming. Consolidation may further shrink newsrooms.

By Stephen Battaglio and Cerys Davies

Ellina Abovian, a veteran correspondent for KTLA-TV, was recently on assignment covering a story about Los Angeles International Airport when she received a message that every media business professional dreads.

She was asked to see her boss at the station when she was done. At the meeting, she was told she would be losing her job after 11 years.

"I was totally blindsided," said Abovian, 40. "There was no indication."

The Glendale native was among several longtime KTLA personalities who were laid off amid a wave of cuts at outlets owned by Nexstar Media Group in Los Angeles and other cities. They included midday anchors Glen Walker and Lu Parker along with veteran meteorologist Mark Kriski, who first joined the station

in 1991.

The layoffs prompted an outpouring of support for the journalists among Los Angeles TV viewers, who saw them as friends and neighbors. Abovian said she received more than 20,000 messages of support.

"I had no idea that people felt so strongly," Abovian said in an interview. "For people to say, 'I loved hearing your voice,' and remember all these little moments. ... It's sad because you have these people in your living room every day."

Once the primary source of community news and information, local TV news stations are struggling with their own tough story, one marked by declining ratings, stagnant revenue growth and rapid shifts in how media are consumed in the [See News, A12]

Data centers face state scrutiny

Bills target health, energy issues from AI demands

By Katie King



A DUSTY haze settles over Imperial, Calif., near a proposed data center site. GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

ICE will deploy to U.S. airports, Trump affirms

Agents are to assist TSA starting Monday, he says, a plan that draws bipartisan fire.

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA AND MARK OLSEN

What began as a social media post from President Trump on Saturday has grown quickly into a full-scale plan to deploy ICE agents to U.S. airports.

Amid a partial government shutdown, Transportation Security Administration lines have grown to be hours long at some U.S. airports. Call-out rates have started to increase at some airports, and the Department of Homeland Security said at least 376 TSA agents have quit since the partial shutdown began Feb. 14.

Helping to feed unpaid workers

As TSA agents struggle with bills, nonprofits are stepping up. **NATION, A10**

Travelers' advice: Pay TSA, now

Passengers enduring long waits express frustration at shutdown. **NATION, A10**

By Sunday, Trump posted on his Truth Social platform that ICE would indeed deploy to airports beginning Monday.

White House border advisor Tom Homan provided additional details earlier in the day during a televised interview, saying that U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement plans to dispatch [See Airports, A10]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

TRAVELERS head to a security line at LAX. TSA wait times have grown amid a partial shutdown.

Lesson plans pivot over Chavez legacy

Educators at colleges, K-12 schools rethink their curriculum after sex abuse allegations.

By JAWEED KALEEM, HOWARD BLUME AND KATE SEQUEIRA

Intense angst over Cesar Chavez's legacy amid sexual abuse allegations is rippling through California classrooms, prompting teachers, scholars and school systems to urgently revamp lessons about one of California's most widely taught historic figures.

Educators at K-12 and university campuses are re-writing lesson plans, reframing discussions and preparing for difficult conversations with students about the labor leader's life and contradictions.

Teachers say they don't

have the luxury of waiting for new state, district or university guidance. Instead, they are pivoting in real time, with little more than rapidly evolving news coverage, student input and their own judgment to guide them.

"The regular class plan went out the window," said Kimberly Young, who teaches ethnic studies at Culver City High School and led a discussion last week on the allegations first revealed in the New York Times.

At UCLA, Chicana/o and Central American studies faculty are grappling with how to present Chavez's influence on social movements after they voted to cut his name from the department title. Schoolteachers are girding to address students' questions, anger and confusion over a figure whose name and books are deeply embedded in state [See Chavez, A7]

Iran issues new strait warning

After Trump's threat to destroy power plants, Tehran says it may "completely" close oil passage. **WORLD, A2**

Candidates urge debate boycott

Democratic governor hopefuls excluded from USC event note that it left out people of color. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Disney artist's hidden tribute

Legacy Tower at Downtown Disney includes a nod to five Black architects. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Very warm. L.A. Basin: 86/59. **B6**

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